viewed by the Chinese as part of their larger strategy of creating an anti-American united front. [35] It also meant that India's prestige and standing in the world could be leveraged by China to make inroads into the international community and to expand China's diplomatic space, especially among the Third World countries, in the early 1950s. India also sponsored and supported the People's Republic of China's claim to be given the Chinese seat in the United Nations and its Security Council. Most importantly for China, India's recognition provided the space for China to prepare for the invasion of Tibet in late 1950, secure in the knowledge that diplomatic relations would make it much harder, if not impossible, for India to interfere in the process.

What did India gain from the early recognition of China? India's international stature received a temporary boost. As a result of the good relations with both China and America, India played a role in the Korean peninsula. Nehru may have gained in personal stature. However, India squandered the first-mover advantage by not seeking substantive gains. India's recognition neither secured the friendship of China nor the security of India's northern frontier. The Chinese state-run media continued to attack India and Nehru throughout 1950 as a lackey of the Anglo-Americans. And, declassified Chinese documents show that the Chinese Communists deeply distrusted Nehru and India even when they had recognized the People's Republic of China. They continued to suspect that India had sinister motives with regard to Tibet. After the invasion, they alleged that India had interfered in China's internal affairs, leading Patel to comment that 'even though we regard ourselves as friends of China, the Chinese do not regard us as their friends'. Neither did the establishment of diplomatic relations guarantee the security of India. As Patel put it, 'The undefined state of the frontier and the existence on our side of a